Wizard of Oz Prototyping

Wizard of Oz prototypes are prototypes with faked functions—for instance, interactivity that comes from a human rather than an algorithm or software code, with users believing the latter is the case—that you can use to test with your users. Like the Wizard of Oz in the story (who generates an ominous, magical and deceptive appearance from behind a curtain), you are mimicking some aspects of your product for the sake of prototyping it, allowing you to save time and resources.

The most common example of Wizard of Oz prototypes is a prototype of a digital system where the user is "tricked" into thinking the system responses are computer-driven, when they are actually human-controlled, such as a piece of virtual assistant software in which a real human, working on another computer, types the responses. Note—ethically, we as designers are well within the boundaries when doing this; it does not involve manipulating users for immoral gain.

When to use this method

You are best off using the Wizard of Oz prototyping method when testing interactions of your product before building it. However, as you may have noticed, this prototyping method involves a fair amount of time and effort. Therefore, you can really only make the best use of it for testing the effects and interactions of complex systems or in the later stages of your design project.

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A suggested process

01: Decide what you want to test or explore

- With your team, **note down the key components of your idea or ideas**. This helps you figure out which parts of your idea/s need to be tested with prototypes.
- If you find yourself with many different ideas, that's a good sign that you should start with low-fidelity prototypes to whittle them down into fewer, more effective ideas. Sketch a paper prototype to quickly test and validate your ideas!

02: Figure out a way to mimic or fake the interactions

This requires a fair bit of ingenuity, but you can use ready-made tools such as social media, PowerPoint, instant messaging and videos to create a realistic imitation of computer interactivity. For instance, you could create an interactive PowerPoint presentation and use it together with messages sent to a computer in order to fake the interactions of a social media website without having to code.

- For each idea, **write down a couple of questions you want answered**. What are some assumptions that you want to test? Which parts of your idea are you most unsure about?
- Try to come up with **both broad and narrow questions**. For instance, if your idea is a restaurant reservation app, a broad question could be whether the app solves the user need you identified. A narrow question could be whether a map view is the best way to let users discover restaurants around them.
- Generally, broad questions are best answered through low-fidelity prototypes while narrow questions are best answered through high-fidelity prototypes.

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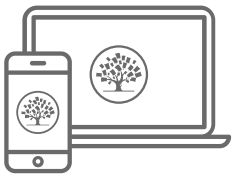

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